

1870 In Paris, a revolutionary commune holds power, but is brutally suppressed at the cost of 20,000 lives by Louis Adolphe Thiers, who serves as president from 1871 until 1873. Instability is endemic in the new republic: over the next 70 years there are 109 separate governments.

1881 Tunisia becomes a French protectorate; in 1887 a protectorate is established in Indochina.

1894 France signs a military alliance with Russia against growing German power in Europe.

1899 After a near conflict at Fashoda, Sudan, France, and UK reach agreement over spheres of influence in Africa.

1904 Entente Cordiale with UK resolves colonial differences over Morocco, Egypt, Suez Canal, and Madagascar, and develops into a diplomatic alliance.

1905 Church and state are separated in the wake of the Dreyfus Affair in which a Jew, Captain Alfred Dreyfus, is unjustly convicted of treason in 1894 and only acquitted in 1906.

1907 UK signs an agreement with Russia, extending its alliance with France to form the Triple Entente.

1912 France and Spain establish protectorates over Morocco.

1914 Germany declares war on France as World War I breaks out. Germany invades France before it turns to face Russia. UK joins the war as an ally of France, and sends a large army. The German advance toward Paris is stopped at the Marne, and by the end of 1914 a stalemate develops along the western front. About 550,000 French soldiers are killed in the Battle of Verdun (February 1915–December 1916), and 200,000 in the second Battle of the Aisne (April–May 1917).

FRANCE

FRENCH OVERSEAS DEPARTMENTS & TERRITORIES

CLIPPERTON ISLAND

French Dependency off coast of Mexico, named after a pirate, John Clipperton
1855 Claimed by France.

EUROPA AND OTHER ISLANDS

Five groups of islands off the west coast of Madagascar and claimed by that country.
1960 Administered by France.

FRENCH GUIANA

Mainland colony in South America.
1568 Gaspar de Sostelle and 126 families attempt to settle but are driven out by the indigenous population.
1676 The territory is recaptured by France from the Dutch.
1817 Territory becomes a French colony and is later used as a penal colony.
1946 Made an Overseas Department.

FRENCH POLYNESIA

Island group in South Pacific.
1521 Ferdinand Magellan reaches Pukapuka in the Tuamotu Archipelago, which is already inhabited by Polynesians.
1768 Tahiti is visited by Louis-Antoine de Bougainville.
1842 France makes Tahiti a protectorate.
1880 Tahiti and its dependants become a French colony. The rest of the island groups are annexed by 1900.
1946 French Polynesia becomes an Overseas Territory.
1963 French government announces plans to begin a nuclear testing program. First test takes place at Mururoa Atoll.
1995 Underground nuclear test on Mururoa Atoll prompts a series of demonstrations and riots in Tahiti.
1995 The last of five Greenpeace vessels accused of entering the 12-mile (20-km) exclusion zone around the atolls is seized by French commandos.
1996 Nuclear tests suspended.

GUADELOUPE

Large island in the eastern Caribbean.
1493 Claimed for Spain by Columbus.
1635 French colony established.
1946 Becomes an Overseas Department.

MARTINIQUE

Large island in the Caribbean.
1502 Claimed for Spain by Columbus.
1635 French colony established.
1946 Becomes an Overseas Department.

MAYOTTE

Island in western Indian Ocean.
1843 French colony, part of the Comoros.
1974 When Comoros is independent, Mayotte becomes Departmental Collective.

NEW CALEDONIA

Large island in southwest Pacific Ocean.
1840 First European settlers arrive.
1853 French colony.
1958 Becomes an Overseas Territory.
1998 Becomes a Territorial Collective; a referendum on independence will be held between 2013 and 2018.

REUNION

Island in Indian Ocean.
1638 French possession as Ile Saint Paul (later Ile Bourbon).
1946 Becomes an Overseas Department.

ST. PIERRE & MIQUELON

Islands off the east coast of Canada.
1816 French colony.
1985 Becomes a Territorial Collective.

SOUTHERN & ANTARCTIC TERRITORIES

Islands in the south Indian Ocean plus the French Antarctic claim.
1955 Organized as an Overseas Territory.

WALLIS & FUTUNA

Islands in the central Pacific Ocean.
1961 Become an Overseas Territory.

RESISTANCE LEADER AND PRESIDENT (1890–1970)

CHARLES DE GAULLE

The man commonly referred to in France as Général de Gaulle was a French military leader and statesman.

Prior to World War II, de Gaulle was an armored warfare tactician. After war broke out, he reached the rank of brigadier general, becoming leader of the Free French government in London and of the French Resistance. Following liberation in 1944, he led the French provisional government.

Called to form a government in 1958, de Gaulle was the Fifth Republic's first president, 1958–69. His political ideology, known as Gaullism, has had a lasting influence on French politics.



“The cause of France is not lost... Whatever happens, **the flame** of French resistance must not and **shall not die.**”

GENERAL DE GAULLE, BROADCASTING FROM LONDON, JUNE 18, 1940

1918 The Allies break through German lines in the summer of 1918 and force an armistice in November.

1919 The peace treaties signed at Versailles outside Paris return Alsace and Lorraine to France, award France mandates over Saarland in Germany, and satisfy French demand for German reparations. By later agreements, France receives mandates over Lebanon and Syria, and territories in West Africa.

1919–39 Economic recession and political instability as the Third Republic has 44 governments.

1923 French troops occupy the Ruhr to enforce German reparation payments. They withdraw in 1925 as the Locarno Pact confirms the existing Franco–German border and promises better relations between the two powers.

1933 Hitler comes to power in Germany and begins to dismantle the Versailles settlement. UK and France appease Germany at Munich in 1938, but offer support to Poland when Hitler occupies neighboring Czechoslovakia in 1939.

1939 German invasion of Poland starts World War II. France and UK declare war.

1940 Germany invades and forces a French capitulation; a collaborationist regime under Marshal Pétain, hero of the defense of Verdun in 1916, is set up in Vichy in the south as the Germans control the north and west of the country. General de Gaulle leads the “Free French” from London.

1943–44 France recognizes the independence of Syria and Lebanon.

1944 Liberation of France as Allied troops invade Normandy on D-Day. De Gaulle takes over as leader of the provisional government.

1945 World War II ends: France joins in the four-power occupation of Germany.

1946–58 Fourth Republic is set up but is plagued by political instability.

1949 France joins NATO.

1950 Schuman plan for the union of French and West German iron, steel, and coal industries in order to prevent another war between the two nations leads to the establishment of the European Coal and Steel Community (ECSC) with West Germany,

Liberation

On August 26, 1944, crowds cheered Allied troops in a victory parade down the Champs Élysées. The German garrison surrendered the previous day.

